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EPISODE 73

Birkat HaMazon: Zimmoon

By Joseph Mosseri · Oct 15, 2020

Birkat HaMazon. There are many laws and customs attached to Birkat HaMazon. In fact, before we even begin saying Birkat HaMazon, we have certain actions that we do, certain things that are connected to Birkat HaMazon. Firstly, we have Pesukim that we say prior to Birkat HaMazon. If we are three or more men eating together, we say Zimmoon, and there is another less common practice of having a cup of wine that we hold from that point of Zimmoon, and which we make Kos Shel Berakhah and HaGefen at the end of Birkat HaMazon.

So what are our specific Minhagim? So we have a litany of Pesukim that are said before Birkat HaMazon, sometimes even Mizmorim prior to those Pesukim. The Zimmoon is a very, very simple form based upon Shulhan 'Arukh. It's "Nebarekh SheAkhalnu Mishelo," with the response of "Barukh SheAkhalnu Mishelo UBeTubo Hayyinu," and finally, we have that cup of Birkat HaMazon that may or may not be used.

So let's talk about these Minhagim. Let's deal with the cup first, because if you're going to be doing Zimmoon, that's generally when the cup comes into play. Even though according to the Gemara in Masekhet Pesahim, it seems that you need a cup of wine to end Birkat HaMazon even if you're just one person by yourself, that is not the practice. According to the Midrash HaNe'elam of Megillat Rut, if you are three or more eating together, you must have a cup of wine, and that is also the practice of the Mekubbalim according to the Ari. But according to the Rif, according to the Rambam, according to the Meiri, and according to the final opinion in Shulhan 'Arukh, even if three or more men are eating together, there is no obligation whatsoever to have a cup of wine. In other words, it's a nice practice, it's a Missvah Min HaMubhar, meaning it's the choicest way to do the Missvah, but it's not obligatory, and therefore the common practice, the common Minhag within community at large and among Sefaradim at large, is not to use a cup of wine to end Birkat HaMazon. That being said, if you are using that cup of wine, you start holding that cup of wine from the beginning of Zimmoon.

So what is Zimmoon? Zimmoon is when we have three or more men together, we would basically have an invitation, a summoning to Birkat HaMazon, and it's an invitation to come together, to join together, to know that we're going to focus and begin Birkat HaMazon. Shulhan 'Arukh clearly says that the wording for Zimmoon is very, very short, sweet and simple, and this is our custom.

The person leading the Zimmoon says "Nebarekh SheAkhalnu Mishelo," those there respond "Barukh SheAkhalnu Mishelo UBeTubo Hayyinu," and the person leading then repeats that line "Barukh SheAkhalnu Mishelo UBeTubo Hayyinu." The text is very clear from Shulhan 'Arukh, also from the Rif, from the Rambam, that those are the words: "Barukh SheAkhalnu Mishelo UBeTubo Hayyinu," and not like you find in other Siddurim today, "SheAkhalnu," "MiTubo HaGadol," "Tamid MiTubo HaGadol." We don't add all these extra words. "Barukh SheAkhalnu Mishelo UBeTubo Hayyinu," that is our Minhag.

Now, before we even do the "Nebarekh," there is another Minhag of saying either "Birshutkhem," or "Birshut Morai VeRabotai," or "Birshut Mor Abi," or "Birshut HaKohanim" prior to that, and the response would be "Birshut Shamayim" or in short just "Shamayim," and that would be before the "Nebarekh," and that is a very common practice, and you find it in our Siddurim. Unfortunately though, based upon many Siddurim coming from Israel today based upon the teachings of the Ben Ish Hai, there is another introduction that we see there, and it says "Hab Lana VeNebarikh LeMalka 'Ila'ah Kadisha," "Birshut Malka 'Ila'ah Kadisha UBirshutkhem." It is not our Minhag to say such a thing. This verbiage does not appear in the writings of the Hida, does not appear in the writings of Rabbi Hayyim Palacci. It is not our Minhag to say such a thing.

And even though it would seem from the Zohar that you have to say those three words of "Hab Lana VeNebarikh," we do not do it, and based upon the Ari himself, he tells us that because we say the Pesukim prior to Birkat HaMazon, and specifically the Pasuk of "Abarekhah Et Ad-onai BeKhol 'Et," "Tamid Tehilato BeFi," which is a Pasuk from Tehillim, Mizmor Lamed-Dalet, Pasuk Bet, and that Pasuk means, "I will come to praise God," that means you've already set yourself up with the proper frame of mind to be saying Birkat HaMazon. That "Abarekhah Et Ad-onai BeKhol 'Et" is a complete replacement for "Hab Lan VeNebarikh," and therefore anybody saying "Abarekhah" does not say "Hab Lan," and that is our Minhag.

So we start with "Abarekhah," we go to the regular Zimmoon of "Birshutkhem," "Birshut Shamayim," "Nebarekh SheAkhalnu Mishelo," etc., like I said. And if you are using a cup of wine, you'd be holding a cup of wine from the time of Zimmoon.

Next time, we'll talk about other Minhagim connected to Birkat HaMazon.

(Disclaimer: This is a transcript of a video episode and may contain spelling or grammatical errors. As this transcript was generated from video, it may not fully capture the speaker's tone, emphasis, or intent — we recommend watching the video for the full experience and accuracy.)